



With Russian forces drawing near, members of Ukraine’s Third Army Corps have erected anti-drone netting over roads in Izium.

Ukrainian City Dreads Return Of the Invaders

By CASSANDRA VINOGRAD and OLEKSANDR CHUBKO

IZIUM, Ukraine — Unknown woman. Unknown woman. Bits of bone. Unknown woman, six more times — all hand scrawled on signs tacked to rough wooden crosses.

The line of graves is a visceral reminder of the enduring horrors of Russia's occupation four years ago of the eastern Ukrainian city of Izium. Now, as Moscow's forces again move closer, battering Izium with glide bombs and drones, residents fear that another battle for the city would be far worse than what came before.

After the five-month occupation in 2022, Russian troops left behind a mass grave and ruined buildings, scars that remain fresh. All 447 bodies from the grave were exhumed and reburied on a hilltop, including the still unidentified remains.

On a recent rainy afternoon, smoke from a Russian strike rose within sight of the reburied bodies. Residents are under no illusion: Given the chance, they say, Russia will not stop until Izium's complete destruction.

Moscow has never retaken a major city that it once occupied in this war and then lost. Izium is not yet in imminent danger of being captured or destroyed. But people there are bracing for the worst, while maintaining hope that Ukrainian forces will continue to hold the line. Ukraine's military has dug new defenses around the city and rehearsed operations to fend off a large-scale assault.

"We have to plan for every scenario," said one local commander, who in keeping with military protocol asked to be identified by his call sign, Coach.

Izium, with its high elevation overlooking steppes, was a strategic stronghold for armies across centuries, from the Cossacks in the 1600s to the Nazis in World War II.

Mykola Kaliuzhny, a journalist, grew up hearing his mother's stories about life in Izium under

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Quietly, Vance Sought Blunt Views on Iran

This article is by Jonathan Swan, Adam Entous and Maggie Haberman.

WASHINGTON — Vice President JD Vance took the unusual step over the spring and summer of calling U.S. military commanders in the Middle East, Europe and Asia directly, seeking their unvarnished assessments of the Iran war, according to current and former officials.

Mr. Vance, who opposed the war from the outset and was charged by President Trump with helping to end the conflict, wanted the commanders' individual judgments, in their own words, before

Was Deeply Concerned by Military Accounts on War’s Prospects

they were consolidated into a Pentagon view.

The conversations delved into an array of issues related to the war, including its objectives, tactics, casualty estimates, what the Iranians would do in the Strait of Hormuz, how adaptable they had become and how much punishment their government could absorb. Mr. Vance also asked for a

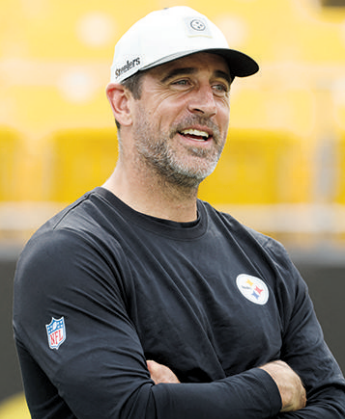
detailed accounting of what remained in the commanders' stockpiles, and how the transfer of weapons to the Middle East would affect their ability to deter China, Russia and North Korea.

On that last point, the commanders were blunt. They were most worried about their depleted stocks of Patriot interceptors, the backbone of their air defenses. By late spring, one theater was down to fewer than 100 of them. The war had also exhausted the theater's supplies of the Army Tactical Missile Systems, which can reach 190 miles, along with stores of the Precision Strike Missiles, which were

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A New N.F.L. Season, in Focus

Can the New York Giants' new coach, John Harbaugh, make the team better immediately? Can the veteran quarterbacks Aaron Rodgers and Patrick Mahomes return to glory? Special Section.

Leaders in A.I. Urge Restraint On Its Growth

By MIKE ISAAC

SAN FRANCISCO — Dario Amodei, the chief executive of Anthropic, called for a global slowdown of artificial intelligence development in a 3,800-word essay on Saturday, just days after one of the company's employees quit over concerns about the safety of the technology.

The leaders of two other top A.I. companies quickly signed on to the effort. Sam Altman, the chief executive of OpenAI, and Elon Musk, whose SpaceX rocket company has been ramping up spending on A.I., said in social media posts that they agreed on the need for a slower pace.

Mr. Amodei, who co-founded Anthropic to focus on securely and carefully building A.I., wrote in his essay that while he believed the technology could bring many benefits, it was advancing at too quick a pace for researchers to continue safely.

"Over the last few months, I have become convinced that fully addressing the risks requires even more prudence — not just investing in risk prevention, but pacing the rate of capabilities ad

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NEWS ANALYSIS

A Sweeping Effort To Stifle Free Speech

Trump Deploys Agencies and Lawsuits

By JIM RUTENBERG and MAGGIE HABERMAN

The Justice Department has sent F.B.I. agents to reporters' homes to serve subpoenas and, in at least one case, flashed a warrant to seize devices. The Pentagon has fired the editor and publisher of its traditionally independent newspaper, Stars and Stripes, and blocked access to other journalists who refused to sign pledges that would limit their reporting.

Regulatory agencies are using their powers to pressure media organizations over their content. The administration has stripped funding from public television and radio. Angry over stories he does not like, President Trump has sued major news organizations and the White House has taken control of the previously independent press pool that tracks the president, deciding which outlets can participate.

Almost 20 months into Mr. Trump's second term, his long-running media clashes have grown into a sweeping campaign to control speech in America that stands out for applying so many levers, so fast, all at once.

Driven by personal pique, fury over leaks and a determination to shape the political narrative to his advantage, Mr. Trump is deploying the might of the federal government and filing personal lawsuits — targeting not just journalists and liberal critics, but also comedians and talk show hosts, and the corporate entities behind them.

To the president and his allies, he is simply demanding accountability for what he casts as biased, unfair and sometimes inaccurate coverage and criti-

cism — an effort that has been welcomed by longtime conservative press critics like those at the Media Research Center.

Aides noted that the White House has this year expanded who gets invited to cover events, such as the off-the-record presidential lunch with network anchors that precedes the annual State of the Union address.

In a statement, Steven Cheung, the White House communications director, said that "biased reporting from the media is a disservice to the American people." Pointing to Mr. Trump's heavy rotation of question-and-answer sessions with reporters as evidence of "unprecedented access," he added: "We utilize every tool available to ensure that accurate reporting is provided to the public and the stain of those who knowingly peddle false information is held accountable."

Free speech advocates say the president's intent is apparent: to punish, intimidate and silence dissenters.

"There's not a week that goes by where they're not taking a new step to curtail press freedom in the country," said Clayton Weimers, the executive director of the North America division of Reporters Without Borders. "We have measured a substantial diminishment of press freedoms."

When challenged in court, the president and the administration have frequently lost, confronted with strongly worded rulings from judges affirming First

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GRANT HINDSLEY FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

The Seattle raccoon captured in a mural by Andrew Miller.

Jimothy Joins the Menagerie That Tugs at Our Heartstrings

By KURT STREETER

SEATTLE — He has no neck. That's what stopped the internet in its tracks: a raccoon whose head sits directly on his shoulders. A raccoon who runs without appearing to travel, loping in the manner of a man crossing a hot parking lot in flip-flops.

His name, if you're one of the few who haven't heard, is Jimothy. He lives in my part of Seattle, and that's as precise as I'll get. Nobody around here wants the world clogging our street corners, hoping for a glimpse. Which hasn't, however, stopped me.

On the evening of July 13, Kiana Hall saw something moving under a parked car near her home. A cat, she thought. Then it stepped into the light. She got a few seconds of

video and uttered what remains the best single line spoken on this subject.

"What am I looking at?"

She posted it to her friends, saying that she and her husband had been blessed by a Jimothy. Why Jimothy? To her, he just looked like one. Nobody has come up with anything better.

By morning, her video was ricocheting worldwide. Within a week, it had racked up 10 million views and media from Germany to the Philippines to New Zealand were calling Ms. Hall. Soon, Jimothy was the subject of a mural, tattoos at a shop up the street, a cryptocurrency, a charity auction that raised \$271,975 for a food

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METROPOLITAN

When Death Is a Patient’s Goal
With medical aid in dying legal in New York State, nine clinical professionals started Quietus, a practice to help people die on their own terms.
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SUNDAY BUSINESS

How a Montessori Chain Failed
Ray Girn said he wanted to do for preschools “what ride-sharing apps or Airbnb have achieved.” It became a \$440 million fiasco.
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DESIGN

The Magic of Green Spaces
Indoor and outdoor landscapes — on walls, in gardens and on rooftops — excite the eye, calm nerves and sometimes feed butterflies. SPECIAL SECTION

SUNDAY STYLES

Coming Soon: Robot Butlers
What do 10-year-olds think life will be like in 2050? Some are worried, but others foresee mind-reading laptops and female presidents.
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SUNDAY OPINION

Stephen Witt
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